

OTEL-99: Best Practice Summary

Series: OTEL — OpenTelemetry Integration | Notebook: 99 | Created: March 2026 | Last Updated: 10/02/2026

Introduction

This notebook consolidates every actionable best practice from the OTEL series (notebooks 01-08) into definitive, reference-ready tables. Each practice specifies the exact setting or value to use, a priority level, and its category. Use this as a checklist when planning, deploying, or auditing OpenTelemetry integration with Dynatrace.

Table of Contents

- 1. Collector Configuration
- 2. Deployment and Sizing
- 3. Security
- 4. Dynatrace OTLP Integration
- 5. Resource Attributes and Entity Mapping
- 6. Trace Instrumentation
- 7. Metrics Instrumentation
- 8. Logs Instrumentation
- 9. Semantic Conventions
- 10. Performance and Reliability
- 11. Troubleshooting and Observability

1. Collector Configuration

#	Best Practice	Recommended Setting/Value	Priority	Source
1	Always use the <code>batch</code> processor	<code>processors.batch.timeout: 10s</code> , <code>send_batch_size: 1000</code> , <code>send_batch_max_size: 1500</code>	Critical	OTEL-02
2	Always use the <code>memory_limiter</code> processor	<code>processors.memory_limiter.check_interval: 1s</code> , <code>limit_mib: 80%</code> of container memory, <code>spike_limit_mib: 25%</code> of limit	Critical	OTEL-02
3	Place <code>memory_limiter</code> first in every pipeline	<code>processors: [memory_limiter, resource, batch]</code>	Critical	OTEL-02, OTEL-08
4	Pin Collector image to a specific version	<code>image: otel/opentelemetry-collector-contrib:0.151.0</code> (never <code>latest</code>)	Critical	OTEL-03, OTEL-07
5	Validate config before deploy	Run <code>otelcol-contrib validate --config=config.yaml</code>	Critical	OTEL-08

#	Best Practice	Recommended Setting/Value	Priority	Source
6	Use the Contrib or Dynatrace distribution	otel/opentelemetry-collector-contrib or ghcr.io/dynatrace/dynatrace-otel-collector/dynatrace-otel-collector	Recommended	OTEL-02, OTEL-07
7	Use GOMEMLIMIT instead of deprecated memory_ballast	Set GOMEMLIMIT env var to ~80% of container memory limit	Critical	OTEL-02
8	Use environment variables for all secrets	`\${DT_API_TOKEN}`, `\${DT_ENV_ID}` in YAML config	Critical	OTEL-02
9	Add a default service.name via resource processor	processors.resource.attributes: [{key: service.name, value: "unknown-service", action: insert}]	Recommended	OTEL-07, OTEL-08
10	Enable retry on failure for exporters	retry_on_failure.enabled: true, initial_interval: 5s, max_interval: 30s, max_elapsed_time: 300s	Recommended	OTEL-03, OTEL-07

2. Deployment and Sizing

#	Best Practice	Recommended Setting/Value	Priority	Source
11	Use DaemonSet (agent mode) for per-node collection	kind: DaemonSet in K8s manifest	Recommended	OTEL-03
12	Use Deployment (gateway mode) for centralized processing	kind: Deployment with replicas: 2+	Recommended	OTEL-03
13	Size gateway resources by measured throughput	Community starting points — <1k spans/s: 100m/256Mi; <10k: 500m/1Gi; <100k: 2/4Gi; >100k: 4+/8Gi+ — then resize from your own memory headroom	Critical	OTEL-03
14	Set memory_limiter.limit_mib to 80% of container memory limit	Container limit 1Gi -> limit_mib: 800	Critical	OTEL-03
15	Deploy gateway with minimum 2 replicas for HA	spec.replicas: 2	Recommended	OTEL-03
16	Add PodDisruptionBudget for gateway	minAvailable: 1	Recommended	OTEL-03
17	Use HorizontalPodAutoscaler at 70% CPU target	averageUtilization: 70, minReplicas: 2, maxReplicas: 10	Recommended	OTEL-03
18	Enable persistent queue for gateway exporters	sending_queue.enabled: true, queue_size: 1000, storage: file_storage	Recommended	OTEL-03
19	Install via Helm for K8s deployments	helm install otel-collector open-telemetry/opentelemetry-collector --set mode=deployment	Recommended	OTEL-03
20	Fix time zones where text timestamps are parsed	OTLP timestamps are epoch nanoseconds with no zone; set the location on the file_log time parser, not the container TZ	Recommended	OTEL-08

3. Security

#	Best Practice	Recommended Setting/Value	Priority	Source
21	Store API tokens in Kubernetes Secrets	<code>kind: Secret</code> , reference via <code>secretKeyRef</code>	Critical	OTEL-03
22	Enable TLS on receiver endpoints	<code>tls.cert_file</code> , <code>tls.key_file</code> on <code>otlp.protocols.grpc</code> and <code>.http</code>	Critical	OTEL-03
23	Enable mTLS for internal traffic	<code>tls.client_ca_file</code> on receiver	Optional	OTEL-03
24	Apply NetworkPolicy to restrict Collector ingress/egress	Allow ingress 4317/4318 from app namespaces; egress 443 to Dynatrace only	Recommended	OTEL-03
25	Strip sensitive attributes in the processor pipeline	<code>processors.attributes.actions</code> : [{key: <code>api.key</code> , action: <code>delete</code> }]	Critical	OTEL-02
26	Never embed tokens in code or config files	Always use env vars or Secret references	Critical	OTEL-07
27	Never include PII in span or metric attributes	Exclude user emails, SSNs, credit card numbers	Critical	OTEL-04

4. Dynatrace OTLP Integration

#	Best Practice	Recommended Setting/Value	Priority	Source
28	Use OTLP/HTTP with binary protobuf for direct Dynatrace ingest	<code>exporters.otlhttp.endpoint</code> : <code>https://{env-id}.live.dynatrace.com/api/v2/otlp</code> — JSON payloads are not supported	Critical	OTEL-01, OTEL-07
29	Route gRPC through a Collector (gRPC is not supported for direct DT ingest)	Collector with <code>otlp</code> gRPC receiver + <code>otlhttp</code> exporter to Dynatrace	Critical	OTEL-01, OTEL-07
30	Match the auth scheme to the token	Classic token: <code>Authorization: Api-Token <token></code> . Platform token: <code>Authorization: Bearer <token></code>	Critical	OTEL-07
31	Create a dedicated token with minimum required scopes	Platform: <code>openpipeline:traces:ingest</code> + <code>openpipeline:metrics:ingest</code> + <code>openpipeline:logs:ingest</code> . Classic: <code>openTelemetryTrace.ingest</code> + <code>metrics.ingest</code> + <code>logs.ingest</code>	Critical	OTEL-01, OTEL-07
32	Use Dynatrace Collector distribution for production	<code>ghcr.io/dynatrace/dynatrace-otel-collector/dynatrace-otel-collector</code>	Recommended	OTEL-07
33	Use ActiveGate endpoint for on-prem or network-restricted envs	<code>https://{activegate-host}:9999/e/{env-id}/api/v2/otlp</code>	Recommended	OTEL-07
34	Use Dynatrace Operator OTLP auto-config for K8s (v1.8+)	Annotation <code>otlp-exporter-configuration.dynatrace.com/inject</code> for per-pod control	Recommended	OTEL-07

#	Best Practice	Recommended Setting/Value	Priority	Source
35	Inventory OTLP metric dimensions before enabling Advanced OTLP metric dimensions	All attributes become dimensions, keys keep their case, and histograms change type (Counter → Histogram) — re-check SLOs, alerts and dashboards afterwards	Critical	OTEL-05, OTEL-07

5. Resource Attributes and Entity Mapping

#	Best Practice	Recommended Setting/Value	Priority	Source
36	Always set <code>service.name</code> resource attribute	<code>resource.create({"service.name": "checkout-api"})</code>	Critical	OTEL-07, OTEL-08
37	Set <code>service.version</code> for release tracking	<code>"service.version": "1.2.3"</code>	Recommended	OTEL-07
38	Set <code>service.namespace</code> for service grouping	<code>"service.namespace": "ecommerce"</code>	Recommended	OTEL-07
39	Set <code>deployment.environment.name</code> for environment identification	<code>"deployment.environment.name": "production"</code> (use stable name, not legacy <code>deployment.environment</code>)	Recommended	OTEL-01, OTEL-07
40	Set K8s resource attributes for entity linking	<code>k8s.namespace.name</code> , <code>k8s.pod.name</code> , <code>k8s.deployment.name</code>	Recommended	OTEL-01, OTEL-07
41	Use <code>resourcedetection</code> processor for cloud/K8s metadata	<code>processors.resourcedetection</code> with env, gcp, aws, azure, or k8s detectors	Recommended	OTEL-02

6. Trace Instrumentation

#	Best Practice	Recommended Setting/Value	Priority	Source
42	Start with auto-instrumentation, add manual spans for business logic	Auto-instrument frameworks; add custom spans with <code>tracer.start_as_current_span()</code>	Recommended	OTEL-04
43	Use low-cardinality span names	HTTP GET /users/{id} not HTTP GET /users/12345	Critical	OTEL-04
44	Use descriptive, operation-based span names	<code>process_order</code> , <code>db.query</code> not <code>order_abc123</code> , <code>SELECT * FROM...</code>	Critical	OTEL-04
45	Always record errors on spans	<code>span.record_exception(e)</code> + <code>span.set_status(StatusCode.ERROR, str(e))</code>	Critical	OTEL-04
46	Add business context as span attributes	<code>span.set_attribute("order.id", order_id)</code>	Recommended	OTEL-04
47	Use span events for key milestones	<code>span.add_event("payment_completed", {"transaction_id": txn_id})</code>	Optional	OTEL-04

#	Best Practice	Recommended Setting/Value	Priority	Source
48	Use <code>BatchSpanProcessor</code> (never <code>SimpleSpanProcessor</code> in production)	<code>provider.add_span_processor(BatchSpanProcessor(exporter))</code>	Critical	OTEL-04
49	Use W3C Trace Context propagation (required for OneAgent interop)	<code>W3CTraceparentPropagator + W3CTracestatePropagator</code>	Critical	OTEL-04, OTEL-07
50	Propagate context across async boundaries	Attach/detach context explicitly in async code	Critical	OTEL-04, OTEL-08
51	Propagate context in messaging (Kafka, RabbitMQ)	Inject context into message headers on produce; extract on consume	Recommended	OTEL-04
52	Use <code>TraceIdRatioBased</code> sampler to control trace volume	<code>TraceIdRatioBased(0.1)</code> for 10% sampling in high-throughput envs	Recommended	OTEL-08

7. Metrics Instrumentation

#	Best Practice	Recommended Setting/Value	Priority	Source
53	Choose the correct instrument type	Counter for monotonic; Histogram for durations/sizes; UpDownCounter for gauges; ObservableGauge for current state	Critical	OTEL-05
54	Use hierarchical metric naming	<code><domain>.<component>.<metric></code> e.g. <code>http.server.request.duration</code>	Recommended	OTEL-05
55	Use the semantic-convention unit	<code>http.server.request.duration</code> is a Histogram in <code>s</code> (seconds); <code>unit="By"</code> for bytes. Never reuse a convention name with a different unit	Recommended	OTEL-05
56	Keep attribute cardinality low	Use route templates (<code>/users/{id}</code>), status classes (<code>2xx</code>), never user IDs or timestamps	Critical	OTEL-05
57	Configure explicit histogram bucket boundaries	<code>boundaries: [0.005, 0.01, 0.025, 0.05, 0.1, 0.25, 0.5, 1, 2.5, 5, 10]</code> (seconds) for response times	Recommended	OTEL-05
58	Use Views to drop noisy internal metrics	<code>View(instrument_name="internal.debug.*", aggregation=DropAggregation())</code>	Optional	OTEL-05
59	Use <code>ObservableGauge</code> / <code>ObservableCounter</code> for system stats	Avoid polling in the request hot path	Recommended	OTEL-05
60	Set appropriate export interval	<code>PeriodicExportingMetricReader(exporter, export_interval_millis=60000)</code> (60s default)	Recommended	OTEL-05
61	Measure RED metrics for services	Rate (Counter), Errors (Counter), Duration (Histogram)	Critical	OTEL-05

#	Best Practice	Recommended Setting/Value	Priority	Source
62	Measure USE metrics for resources	Utilization, Saturation, Errors	Recommended	OTEL-05

8. Logs Instrumentation

#	Best Practice	Recommended Setting/Value	Priority	Source
63	Use the Log Bridge pattern (do not replace your logging library)	Attach <code>LoggingHandler</code> to standard Python logger; use Log4j/Logback appenders for Java	Critical	OTEL-06
64	Enable automatic log-trace correlation	Use OTel tracing + log bridge together; <code>trace_id</code> and <code>span_id</code> are injected automatically	Critical	OTEL-06
65	Use structured JSON logging	Output logs as JSON objects with <code>timestamp</code> , <code>level</code> , <code>message</code> , and structured fields	Recommended	OTEL-06
66	Filter DEBUG/TRACE logs at the Collector, not in the app	<code>processors.filter.logs.log_record:</code> <code>['severity_number < 9']</code>	Recommended	OTEL-06
67	Use <code>BatchLogRecordProcessor</code> for log export	Never use synchronous log export in production	Critical	OTEL-06
68	Use the file log receiver for container/file-based log collection	<code>receivers.file_log.include:</code> <code>["/var/log/containers/*.log"]</code> — <code>file_log</code> from collector-contrib v0.149.0; older Collectors only know <code>filelog</code>	Recommended	OTEL-02, OTEL-06
69	Set log severity appropriately	ERROR: unexpected failures; WARN: recoverable issues; INFO: business events; DEBUG: dev only	Recommended	OTEL-06
70	Never log PII or secrets	Exclude passwords, tokens, personal data from log bodies and attributes	Critical	OTEL-06

9. Semantic Conventions

#	Best Practice	Recommended Setting/Value	Priority	Source
71	Migrate to stable HTTP semantic conventions	Use <code>http.request.method</code> (not <code>http.method</code>), <code>http.response.status_code</code> (not <code>http.status_code</code>), <code>url.full</code> (not <code>http.url</code>)	Recommended	OTEL-01
72	Migrate to stable DB semantic conventions	Use <code>db.namespace</code> (not <code>db.name</code>), <code>db.query.text</code> (not <code>db.statement</code>), <code>db.operation.name</code> (not <code>db.operation</code>)	Recommended	OTEL-01
73	Use <code>OTEL_SEMCONV_STABILITY_OPT_IN</code> to control migration	<code>http</code> for stable-only, <code>http/dup</code> for dual-emit during migration; same pattern for <code>database</code>	Recommended	OTEL-01
74	Use stable resource attribute <code>deployment.environment.name</code>	Not the legacy <code>deployment.environment</code>	Recommended	OTEL-01
75	Follow semantic conventions for all standard attributes	Use <code>service.name</code> , <code>service.version</code> , <code>k8s.namespace.name</code> , <code>k8s.pod.name</code> , etc.	Critical	OTEL-01

10. Performance and Reliability

#	Best Practice	Recommended Setting/Value	Priority	Source
76	Derive RED metrics from traces before sampling	<code>span_metrics</code> connector (<code>spanmetrics</code> before contrib v0.151.0) with histogram buckets <code>[100ms, 500ms, 1s, 5s]</code>	Optional	OTEL-02, OTEL-04
77	Filter health-check spans at the Collector	<code>processors.filter.traces.span: ['attributes["url.path"] == "/health"]</code>	Recommended	OTEL-02
78	Use fan-out to send data to multiple backends	Define multiple named exporters under <code>exporters</code> and list all in pipeline	Optional	OTEL-02
79	Increase <code>sending_queue.num_consumers</code> for high throughput	<code>num_consumers: 10</code>	Recommended	OTEL-08
80	Do not over-instrument	Only create spans for meaningful operations; avoid spans on every function call	Recommended	OTEL-04
81	Limit attribute value sizes	Avoid multi-KB strings in span attributes or log bodies	Recommended	OTEL-04
82	Configure proxy for network-restricted environments	<code>exporters.otlphttp.proxy_url: http://proxy.example.com:8080</code> or <code>HTTPS_PROXY</code> env var	Optional	OTEL-08

11. Troubleshooting and Observability

#	Best Practice	Recommended Setting/Value	Priority	Source
83	Enable <code>health_check</code> extension	<code>extensions.health_check.endpoint: 0.0.0.0:13133</code>	Critical	OTEL-02, OTEL-08
84	Enable <code>zpages</code> extension in non-production	<code>extensions.zpages.endpoint: 0.0.0.0:55679</code>	Recommended	OTEL-02, OTEL-08
85	Use <code>debug</code> exporter during development	<code>exporters.debug.verbosity: detailed</code> alongside production exporter	Recommended	OTEL-02, OTEL-08
86	Set Collector log level to <code>info</code> in production, <code>debug</code> for troubleshooting	<code>service.telemetry.logs.level: info</code> (default), switch to <code>debug</code> when investigating	Recommended	OTEL-08
87	Verify tracer provider is not NoOp	In Python: <code>print(trace.get_tracer_provider())</code> must not show <code>NoOpTracerProvider</code>	Critical	OTEL-08

#	Best Practice	Recommended Setting/Value	Priority	Source
88	Test connectivity with curl before deploying	<pre>curl -v https://{env}.live.dynatrace.com/api/v2/otlp/v1/traces -X POST -H "Authorization: Api-Token <token>" -H "Content-Type: application/x-protobuf" --data-binary ''</pre>	Recommended	OTEL-08
89	Troubleshoot systematically: SDK -> Collector -> Backend	Follow the data path; isolate which component is failing	Recommended	OTEL-08
90	Enable pprof extension for Go heap profiling	<code>extensions.pprof.endpoint: 0.0.0.0:1777</code>	Optional	OTEL-08

Summary

This notebook contains **90 best practices** extracted from the OTEL series, organized into 11 categories:

Category	Count	Critical	Recommended	Optional
Collector Configuration	10	6	4	0
Deployment and Sizing	10	2	8	0
Security	7	5	1	1
Dynatrace OTLP Integration	8	5	3	0
Resource Attributes and Entity Mapping	6	1	5	0
Trace Instrumentation	11	6	4	1
Metrics Instrumentation	10	3	6	1
Logs Instrumentation	8	4	3	1
Semantic Conventions	5	1	4	0
Performance and Reliability	7	0	4	3
Troubleshooting and Observability	8	2	5	1
Total	90	35	47	8

Priority guide:

- **Critical** -- Implement before going to production. Skipping causes data loss, security exposure, or broken entity mapping.
- **Recommended** -- Implement for production-grade deployments. Improves reliability, performance, and maintainability.
- **Optional** -- Implement when the specific use case applies. Adds value in targeted scenarios.

References

- [Dynatrace OpenTelemetry Integration](#)
- [Dynatrace Collector Distribution](#)
- [OTLP API Endpoints](#)
- [Configure OTLP Metrics](#)
- [OpenTelemetry Official Docs](#)

- [OTel Collector Configuration](#)
- [Semantic Conventions](#)

This notebook was AI-generated from community-submitted and publicly available sources. This notebook series is not officially supported by Dynatrace. Always verify information against official Dynatrace documentation.